

Your two kids start fighting right in front of you

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Both of them will shade the story in their own favor, so settling who started it rarely gets you anywhere. How you step in changes how often they fight; who gets blamed doesn't.

THE GOAL

You're guiding them through the fight rather than ruling on it. Say one plain sentence describing what you see, with no blame in it.

CHECKLIST

The instant a fight breaks out in front of you and both kids turn to you to settle it.

- ☐ If they're grabbing at each other or at something that could break, get between them and move it out of reach.
- ☐ Say both their names, once, in your normal voice, before you say anything else.
- ☐ Say one plain sentence describing what you see, with no blame in it, like "you're both upset and the game got knocked over."
- ☐ If one of them is bigger or older, catch **the instinct to blame them more**, and ask what happened this time, not what usually happens.
- ☐ Ask each of them the same question: what would make this okay right now?
- ☐ If they can both answer, ask what each is willing to do right now to fix it, instead of telling them the fix yourself.
- ☐ If they land on different answers, have them find one they'd both agree to before you add your own idea.
- ☐ If something got knocked over or broken, have them pick it up or fix it together before you move on.
- ☐ If one owes the other something, an apology or something given back, have them say or do it in their own words.
- ☐ If either is still shouting or crying too hard to answer, give them a set time to calm down first, **say two minutes**.
- ☐ If they're still too worked up to agree on anything, set a time to come back to it, say after dinner, instead of pushing now.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Both of your kids shade what happened in their own favor, so skip asking who's right and **ask what they want to happen instead**.
- 2** When your older kid admits it but explains it away right after, don't take that as more honest, ask what happened before deciding.
- 3** Guiding a fight can take longer than settling it yourself. Mothers who learned to, and their kids, liked it better.

You can't get the real story by asking

KNOW

Both of your kids shade what happened in their own favor, so skip asking who's right and **ask what they want to happen instead**.

Kids showed this same favoring-themselves pattern both in direct answers and in the stories they told afterward. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

When your older kid admits it but explains it away right after, don't take that as more honest, ask what happened before deciding.

Younger kids in that research just **denied doing wrong**, while older kids admitted it but explained it away. [Source 1](#)

Your own sense of fairness is already tilted

DON'T

Don't come down harder on whichever kid is bigger or older just because they should know better.

Parents who lean that way tend to end up with kids who fight more, not less. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

You're not immune to picking a side without noticing: parents tend to give the younger child's version more airtime, and more so the bigger the age gap.

So catch yourself giving the younger kid's account more weight, especially when the age gap is wide. [Source 3](#)

How you step in is what teaches them

DO

Guide the fight instead of deciding it: ask what they feel and let them find the fix.

Kids whose parents did this asked each other for fixes and named feelings far more than kids whose parents intervened as usual. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Guiding a fight can take longer than settling it yourself. Mothers who learned to, and their kids, liked it better.

Mothers trained to guide it, and their kids, both said they liked doing it that way. [Source 5](#)

There's no secret formula, just showing up with one

KNOW

A real, deliberate way of handling these fights makes a difference to how your kids get along, more than no plan at all.

Parents who learned a structured approach, pooled across eight separate trials, made a substantial, if uneven, difference to how their kids got along. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

There's no proven best method: research comparing different structured approaches hasn't found any single type that clearly wins out.

So pick a consistent approach and stick with it, rather than switching every time you read about a different method. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you just stay out of it and let them work it out, they'll settle it fairly between themselves.

ACTUALLY

When researchers filmed how these fights end without a fix from anyone, most ended with no resolution at all, and the next most common ending was **a side giving up**, not a deal both sides reached. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <https://digitalcommons.wayne.edu/mpq/vol50/iss1/6/>
2. <https://psycnet.apa.org/record/1989-04837-001>
3. <https://digitalcommons.wayne.edu/mpq/vol59/iss1/1/>
4. <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=EJ1026590>
5. <https://psycnet.apa.org/psycinfo/2004-11293-013>
6. https://pure.uva.nl/ws/files/68156373/00012003_202108000_00013.pdf
7. <https://psycnet.apa.org/record/1999-05699-004>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Siblings at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)